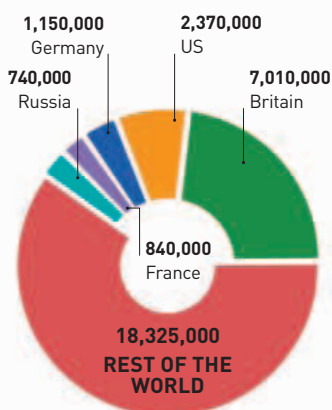




West Indian laborers cutting a channel during the first—and failed—attempt to construct a canal in Panama connecting the Atlantic and Pacific oceans.

BUOYED BY THE SUCCESS OF THE SUEZ CANAL (see 1869), Ferdinand de Lesseps (see 1859) began to draw up plans for a waterway connecting the Atlantic and Pacific oceans through the isthmus of **Panama**. However, the project got off to a difficult start the following year in 1881. There were disagreements over the canal's plans, the machinery did not function well in the terrain, and many workers died of disease in the tropical heat.

Meanwhile, the development of commercial **refrigeration** began to alter the relationship between consumers and producers. Cheese and meats could now be exported long distances. On February 2, the first shipment of frozen meat to survive the journey intact arrived in London from Australia. The following years saw



Shipping tonnage 1881

This chart shows total goods shipped by country in vessels over 100 tons. Refrigeration sparked a rise in food transport and the use of vast ships.

“THE DOOR THAT NOBODY ELSE WILL GO IN AT, SEEMS ALWAYS TO SWING OPEN WIDELY FOR ME.”

Clara Barton, American humanitarian



Clara Barton was the founder of the American Red Cross organization.



THE BOERS

The Boers (“farmers” in Dutch) in South Africa were settlers of Dutch, French Huguenot, and German descent that left the Cape Province in search of autonomy farther north. They spoke Afrikaans, a language that evolved from Dutch. The earliest settlers arrived in the Cape of Good Hope after the Dutch East India Company established a port in 1652. The Boers had a strong ethnic identity and clashed often with the Zulus and the British.

a boom in **shipments** of meats and other agricultural goods from Australia, New Zealand, and Argentina to Europe.

Around the same time, the problem of creating a safe means of artificial light was solved by the US inventor **Thomas Edison** (1847–1931). He had perfected existing designs on **lightbulbs** of the day (see pp.298–99) by preventing them from overheating and making them much safer to use. Almost as soon as he had patented the design, lighting systems began to spring up on the streets, in businesses and hotels, and in homes.

IN SOUTH AFRICA, TENSIONS BETWEEN BOER SETTLERS (see panel, above) and the British over the annexation of the Transvaal (see 1877) had tipped into violence. Boers had established the **South African Republic** in the Transvaal area and begun to use arms to support their claim, starting the First Anglo-Boer War in 1880. British troops suffered a defeat at the hands of the Boer settlers in the battle at Majuba Hill on February 27, 1881, bringing the dispute to an end by March. The **Convention of Pretoria** treaty granted the South African Republic independence over its affairs, although Britain was allowed to maintain an unclear

“suzerainty” over it. This did little to rectify the situation, and the simmering resentment between the British and Boers would erupt again before the end of the century (see 1899).

France, meanwhile, was attempting to extend its influence in North Africa. With Algeria under its control, it looked to the neighboring Ottoman territory of **Tunisia**. The past 50 years had seen Tunisian rulers caught in between Ottoman demands and European creditors, especially after the government went bankrupt in 1869, after which a British, French, and Italian financial commission was imposed on the territory. France decided to send in 36,000 troops in 1881, under the pretext that Tunisians had been moving into Algerian territory. Under the **Treaty of Bardo** that same year, Tunisia became a **French protectorate**. French military occupied the territory and a French minister was installed to liaise with the Tunisian bey (ruler), who now only had limited control.

In **Russia**, there was an outbreak of anti-Jewish violence culminating in **pogroms** in the south of the country, including Kiev, that continued until 1884. This was triggered by the **assassination** of the reformist **Alexander II** (1818–81) who was killed by a group known as People’s Will. False rumors circulated that Jewish people were responsible and that the government was

going to instruct the public to take their revenge on Jews. The violent attacks caused many Jewish people to emigrate to Western Europe, the US, and Palestine.

In the US, teacher and nurse **Clara Barton** (1821–1912) organized the American Red Cross, a part of the growing International Red Cross relief organization that had been founded in 1863.

Meanwhile, in New Mexico, sheriff **Pat Garrett** (1850–1908) captured one of the United States’ most notorious outlaws, **Billy the Kid** (c. 1859–81) on April 30. Born William H. Bonney Jr., Billy the Kid became an infamous gunfighter, and was rumored to have killed at least 27 men by the age of 21. After his arrest he was jailed and sentenced to death, but he escaped until Garrett tracked him down and shot him dead on July 14.



Garrett's gun

A replica of the holster that held Pat Garrett's gun around the time he captured Billy the Kid.

Census puts US population at 50 million

June 29 Tahiti cedes to France

May 2 First shipment of frozen meat from Melbourne, Australia to Britain

July 22 Abdur Rahman Khan becomes emir of Afghanistan

December 20 First Anglo-Boer War (to 1881) over annexation of the South African Republic (Transvaal region)

January 16 Russia attacks Turkmen Fort in Turkmenistan which later becomes part of Russia

March 13 Alexander II of Russia assassinated by bomb, triggering anti-Semitic violence

May 21 US nurse Clara Barton sets up the American Red Cross

French protectorate established in Tunisia

July 20 Indian Wars: Chief Sitting Bull surrenders Sioux people to US troops

July 23 Boundary treaty between Chile and Argentina establishes exact border between them

August 3 Official end to First Anglo-Boer War with Pretoria Convention treaty; South African Republic in Transvaal reestablished